let’s stick with light for now—and make incredible inferences with relatively simple mathematics about the picture of the universe,” Hložek says. “And even if we can do nothing to change it, that knowledge … even if that knowledge goes away, if all humans die, that knowledge right now is incredible. That’s basically why I do what I do.”

I think I see what she’s saying. Would I want to uncover the secrets of the universe, even if I didn’t get to share that knowledge, or keep it? I would. This seems important. “There’s some purpose to doing it, even if it is lost.”

“Because it changes who you are now, right?” she agrees. “I am delighted that we get to live at a time in the universe when we can see dark energy and not be ripped apart by it. But that means the whole point is that you understand it, and then you enjoy it, and then … ‘so long and thanks for all the fish.’ Cool.”

Cool.